Northwind Health Insurance - Underwriting Rules Guide

Product: Individual Health Cover, Silver Plan (NH-2026-01). Guide version 3.2. Effective 1 January 2026.

This internal guide explains how underwriters apply the underwriting terms in policy document NH-2026-01: authority limits, evidence requirements, referrals, decline reasons, postponements and exclusions. Where this guide and the policy document differ, the policy document applies.

This document is a fictional sample created for testing purposes only.

Section 1: Underwriting Authority Levels

Every underwriting decision must be made by someone with the right authority. Cases above a person's limit must be referred up.

Role	Can approve	Must refer to next level
Underwriting assistant	Standard acceptance, no loading, age under 35	Any loading, any declared condition
Underwriter	Loadings up to +40%, exclusions, postponements	Loadings over +40%, any decline
Senior underwriter	Loadings up to +75%, all declines, age 65+	Any case with total loading over +75%
Chief underwriter	Total loading over +75%, exceptions to this guide	None

A total loading is the sum of all individual loadings, as set out in the policy document (for example age +25%, smoker +20% and BMI +15% give a total of +60%).

Section 2: Evidence Requirements

Additional medical evidence is requested only when the declaration alone is not enough to decide.

Situation	Evidence required	Time allowed
Age 50 or over	GP report	21 days
Any declared cardiac condition	Cardiologist report and recent ECG	28 days
Type 2 diabetes	Latest HbA1c result and GP report	21 days
Hypertension	Last three blood pressure readings	14 days
BMI 35 or over	Height and weight confirmed by a GP	14 days
Cancer in remission 5 years or more	Oncologist discharge letter	28 days

If the evidence is not received in the time allowed, the application is closed and the applicant may re-apply. Evidence must be less than 3 months old.

Section 3: Referral Rules

A case must be referred to a senior underwriter when any of the following applies:

(a) The applicant is aged 65 or over.

(b) The applicant declares cancer in remission for 5 years or more.

(c) The applicant consumes more than 35 units of alcohol per week.

(d) Two or more conditions are declared at the same time, for example hypertension and diabetes.

(e) The total loading would be above +40%.

(f) The applicant has had a previous application declined or a policy cancelled by any insurer.

Referred cases must be decided within 5 working days of the evidence being received.

Section 4: Decline Reasons

An application must be declined, and cannot be accepted by an underwriter, in the following cases:

(a) Cancer in remission for less than 5 years.

(b) Type 2 diabetes with kidney, eye or nerve complications.

(c) Any hospital admission for a mental health condition, or any self-harm, unless a specialist report supports a lower risk assessment.

(d) Material non-disclosure found during assessment.

(e) Current treatment for drug or alcohol dependency.

The decline letter must state the reason in plain language and explain the review right: the applicant may ask for a review within 30 days, and a declined application may be reviewed after 12 months, or sooner if there has been a significant change in health.

Section 5: Postponement and Exclusions

A postponement is used when risk may fall with time. The reasons and review dates are:

Reason	Review after
BMI 40 or over	6 months
Uncontrolled hypertension (readings over 160/100)	3 months, with new readings
Investigations in progress for a new symptom	Once results are available
Recent surgery with recovery not complete	6 months from surgery

An exclusion limits cover for a body area or condition instead of refusing it. Standard exclusions are respiratory (asthma with a hospital admission in the last 24 months), spine (recurring back pain) and mental health (an episode of anxiety or depression within 24 months, excluded for 24 months).

Exclusions are recorded on the policy schedule and cannot be removed without new medical evidence.